Personal Essay

Dr. Jonathan Pitts

22 March 2016

I saw you

I'm ankle deep in mud. My cross-country spikes become heavier and heavier with each stride, sucking the energy out of my legs. My vision becomes blurred as I struggle to hold my pace. The pack I'd been running with has thinned, as one by one the athletes fell behind. I can feel the cold, thin air moving in and out of my burning lungs as I pass the three-mile mark. I'm in twelfth place.

I am conscious of two thoughts. First, I am really struggling to hold my pace, and second, they only take sixteen to regionals. I look up, and I see him. He's so easy to pick out of the pack in front of me. Our team's bright gold singlets are the only thing I can focus on in my daze. "Get up to Ethan," I told myself, "You're almost done, you have to push it."

Ethan and I began running together when we were in middle school, and back then, I was considered a pretty fast kid, while Ethan was kind of a no name (as he was just starting his career). I was primarily a sprinter, and he was just trying to figure out what he was good at. When we both got to high school, however, is when we really took off athletically. We got our start at the bottom of the totem pole on the cross-country team, and worked our way up to being the two fastest distance guys at our school, competing for top spots in both our county, and our conference. Growing faster and faster together, Ethan and I became the best of friends. We ran countless miles side by side, talking and laughing together during workouts. He was a great friend to me, and I tried to be one as well. Ethan slowly started to surpass me on the course as we

went through high school, and we had built up a friendly rivalry where every week was a new chance to beat the other.

My competitive edge won't let Ethan beat me without a fight, and it takes everything I have to pass the few runners that I did. It seemed like every time I would make a pass, Ethan, without knowing I was right behind him, would also make a pass which effectively negated my placement compared to his. Three quarters of a mile to go, and I am really suffering at this point. Parents and fans start to line the edges of the course, screaming and cheering for their runner to finish the grueling five kilometers of the race. As the cheering gets louder, the daze in my head only becomes more intense, my vision gets worse, my breathing becomes more forced, and the numbness in my legs starts to take over. Ethan is moving further up in the pack, and I am falling behind. Thirteenth, fourteenth, fifthteenth, I'm on the bubble now, and I know it. I start to panic as I cross the half-mile to go point. "Only one more can pass you," my brain screams. My head is low, and my jaw is locked as I try to hang on long enough. I'm passed again. The chaos in my mind and body is a feeling that I've only had in this scenario as I enter the finishing chute. It seemed like everything was going wrong at once. I can't feel my legs, and I can't form any clear thoughts. Suddenly, everything goes silent. I hear nothing, not even the cheering fans, not even my labored breathing. I watch in slow motion as a pack of three runners overtake me from behind, surrounding me on all sides as they each fight for the sixteenth spot.

I cross the finish line in tears, and crash to the ground. Nineteenth place. My chest is pounding as if I'd been trapped under water. My mind catches up with reality and it hits me; my running career is over, and I vomit in the grass. I look down, first at my neon green spikes that are now completely covered in thick black mud, then up my legs, which are spotted with the same blackness. My eyes then move to my puke stained jersey as I realize that it'll be the last

time I wear it. The last thirty meters of that race is something that I am very ashamed of. My body and mental toughness were broken for the first time in my life that day.

I was bummed out all day at school the next Monday, even though it was my eighteenth birthday. I just couldn't stop thinking about how I didn't have practice after school, and how I wasn't ready to walk away from the sport. Then I saw him. Ethan and my coach were talking in the hallway about practice that day, and Ethan seemed kind of frantic. I didn't really think anything of it at first, but then I realized that that practice was exactly what I needed. I thought that by going to this practice, and running just one more time, would give me the inner peace that I desperately desired. But most of all, I wanted to run to show Ethan that I loved him. I wanted to show my support, and really encourage him to run his best at regionals so he could qualify for the state meet (which was both of our goals). I needed this.

I show up after school with my short shorts, shoes, and Garmin watch, and I ask Ethan and coach if I could run with them. They were happy to agree. The practice was simple, it was no less than eight, but no more than ten four hundred repeats with long strides. Ethan and I ran shoulder to shoulder for every last repeat all within three seconds variation from repeat to repeat. We knew how to run strides, it was something we'd done a thousand times together, but something about this time in particular was different. This time was special. Every single four hundred made me think of a different reason why I love the sport of running. I love the team, I love the smell of the air on race day, I love the feeling of passing that guy, I love sprinting to the finish, I love getting a personal best time, and I love lacing up my shoes at the start. The last four hundred came around, and Ethan looks at me, I already know what he's going to say. Our eyes lock, the intensity in our faces was that of an animal on the hunt, and he says "last one, best one." I give him a nod and a laugh and we take off, still shoulder to shoulder jostling to get the best

position from each other. After we finish the workout, Ethan looks at me again with watery eyes. He said he was so thankful that I came to run with him on my own birthday. He said he was frantically talking with coach during school because he didn't have his training partner to run with that week. It was funny, because all this time I thought I needed to do the workout for me, to give myself peace, and to show my support, but Ethan put his hands on my shoulders and said, "I needed you."

I had an epiphany while running that last repeat. It took me all my life running competitively to realize why I truly love the sport. But during that last workout I arrived at my conclusion.

A lot of people dream about flying. They wonder what it's like, and how it feels. I can tell you that on my eighteenth birthday, I felt what it was like to fly. Running those repeats, I felt like my feet weren't even touching the ground. Every stride was just me propelling my body through the air, because I wasn't getting tired at all. I felt strong, fast, and fierce. I felt like I was on top of the world; I had never felt that way while running before. And that's what I realized I loved most about running. It makes me feel like I'm flying. Being able to share that moment with Ethan that day was more than enough for me to be able to leave the sport of cross country with a clear mind, and was the best birthday present I had ever received.

I decided from then on to form a little tradition for myself. I decided that no matter the weather, no matter the conditions, and no matter how I'm feeling that day, or how much time I have, I am going to run on my birthday every year to remember what it feels like to fly.

The next week goes by, and it's regional Saturday. Of course, I went to the race to watch my friend compete for a spot at the state meet, show my support, and surround myself with the sport that I love. As I was watching Ethan run, he looked like he was struggling more than he

usually does. It was hard to get his attention with my cheering because there were so many people, and I was out of sight. I ran across the course to see the last few meters into the finish. As Ethan came up to the line, something had taken over him like he had new energy, and he finished hard at a great pace just a few slots behind the state qualifying sixteenth.

After the race, I congratulated him, and asked him how he found the energy to finish the way he did. He looked at me, and, with a grin, he said, "I pictured us running together. I saw you."